



IN THE WAKE · [CRUISINGINTHEWAKE.COM](https://cruisinginthewake.com)

7-Night Western Caribbean — Family Edition

MSC World America · 7 Nights from PortMiami

December 5 – 12, 2026 · A family sailing



MSC World America at sea — MSC Cruises' second World-class ship,
delivered March 2025

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**
Written for families sailing this itinerary

Welcome

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier: **MSC World America**, sailing 7 nights from PortMiami, **December 5 – 12, 2026**, calling at **Roatán (Honduras), Costa Maya (Mexico), Cozumel (Mexico), and Ocean Cay (Bahamas)**. It's a family sailing — the week before the Christmas rush, after hurricane season has closed, when the Caribbean is warm and the ship is between the Thanksgiving crowds and the holiday-break crowds.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card, cruise-line and consulate numbers tailored to this itinerary. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

If this is your first MSC sailing — even if you've cruised before — the line feels different from Royal Caribbean, Carnival, NCL, and Princess. We cover the differences in **Section 1** below.

At a Glance

Ship	MSC World America (sister: MSC World Europa , 2022)
Cruise line	MSC Cruises
Class	World Class — MSC's largest, LNG-powered
Specifications	216,638 GT · 1,093 ft / 333 m · 22 decks (16 guest-accessible) · 2,614 cabins · 5,079 double / 6,762 max guests · ~2,138 crew
Year built	2025 (Chantiers de l'Atlantique, Saint-Nazaire, France); Maltese registry

Maiden voyage	April 12, 2025 — PortMiami round-trip Caribbean
Godmother	Drew Barrymore (christened April 9, 2025 at PortMiami, with a Gloria Estefan concert)
Departure port	MSC Miami Cruise Terminal, PortMiami , Florida — the MSC-built terminal that opened April 2025
Itinerary	7 nights / 8 days · Western Caribbean round-trip
Audience	Families with children
Season	Early December — after hurricane season (ends Nov 30), before the Christmas-break crowds
Currency aboard	US Dollar

Ports of call

The day-by-day for the December 5 – 12, 2026 sailing — times from the sailing’s own MSC for Me itinerary (retrieved from the booking, 2026-08-20; re-verify in the app close to sailing):

1. **PortMiami, Florida** — embark Sat Dec 5, ship sails **5:00 PM** (MSC app itinerary) · see </ports/miami.html>
2. **Cruising at sea** — Sun Dec 6
3. **Roatán, Honduras** — Mon Dec 7 (9:00 AM – 6:00 PM)
4. **Costa Maya, Mexico** — Tue Dec 8 (8:00 AM – 5:00 PM)
5. **Cozumel, Mexico** — Wed Dec 9 (9:00 AM – 7:00 PM)
6. **Cruising at sea** — Thu Dec 10
7. **Ocean Cay MSC Marine Reserve, Bahamas** — Fri Dec 11 (**8:00 AM – 8:00 PM** per the MSC app — a late-departure call; see the lighthouse-show note in **Day 7**)
8. **PortMiami, Florida** — disembark Sat Dec 12 (7:00 AM arrival)

All five ports have full standalone port pages on this site.

Table of Contents

- Welcome
 - At a Glance
 - Section 1 — Your Ship: MSC World America
 - Section 2 — Day by Day
 - Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown
 - Section 4 — Packing List
 - Section 5 — Budget Breakdown
 - Section 6 — Emergency Contacts
 - Section 7 — Seasickness
 - Section 8 — Practical Logistics
 - Section 9 — The Family Cruise Rhythm
 - Section 10 — Family Considerations on MSC
 - Section 11 — First Cruise Notes
-

Section 1 — Your Ship: MSC World America

A class-defining ship in her second year of service

MSC World America was delivered March 27, 2025 by Chantiers de l'Atlantique at Saint-Nazaire, France — the second ship of MSC's **World Class** and the first dedicated to the US market. Her maiden voyage left PortMiami on April 12, 2025. By your December 2026 sailing she's a year and a half into service: past any new-ship teething, with the operating crew well-trained and the Caribbean rotation in steady rhythm. For broader context on MSC's positioning in the Caribbean alongside Royal, NCL, and Virgin, **Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026** covers the deployment shifts.

She was christened by actress **Drew Barrymore** at PortMiami on April 9, 2025, with Orlando Bloom on hand and Gloria Estefan performing a concert from the deck. At **216,638 GT and 1,093 feet long**, she's MSC's largest ship and one of the largest cruise ships in the world. Her direct sister is **MSC World Europa** (2022), homeported in the Mediterranean. For a side-by-side comparison against other Caribbean megaships (Symphony of the Seas, Norwegian Aqua, Carnival Mardi Gras, etc.), the **Ship Size Atlas** shows the actual relative scale on a single chart.

What's distinctive about World America

A few features set her apart from anything else your family has likely sailed:

- **The Y-shaped aft.** Most ships have a flat stern. World America's stern is a wedge — a Y-shape with three floor-to-ceiling glass walls that frame the wake. The **World Promenade** (Deck 8) is the seven-deck outdoor walkway that wraps the aft Y, with bars and seating at the rail. The Panorama Lounge above it puts the same view behind a glass wall for cooler evenings — and December evenings on deck are cooler.
- **The World Galleria** — a three-deck central atrium with an LED ceiling that changes scenes throughout the day. The architectural centerpiece of the ship, and the easiest “meet back here” landmark for a family.
- **The Venom Drop @ The Spiral** — an 11-deck dry slide, the longest at sea. Not a waterslide — a dry, friction-controlled enclosed drop. Free. The kids will find it before you do.
- **Cliffhanger** — the only over-water swing ride at sea: four seats on powered arms that lift and swing riders out over the ship's edge, about 160 feet above the water. It lives in **The Harbour**, the outdoor family district aft (water park, themed playground, ropes course, free grab-and-go food). Check the MSC for Me app for cost, height requirements and hours before promising anyone a turn.
- **Eataly at sea.** World America carries the first floating Eataly — the Italian gourmet brand's fresh-pasta, wood-fired-pizza, and gelato concept. Specialty dining (extra charge). On Deck 8.
- **Decks named after Americas port cities** — Cozumel, Nassau, Santos, Miami, Seattle, Halifax, Los Angeles, Buenos Aires, New York, Ocean Cay, San Juan, Ocho Rios. Wayfinding gets easier once you've learned the geography metaphor — a good game to hand the kids on Day 1.

-
- **LNG-powered.** Dual-fuel engines plus Bloom Energy solid-oxide fuel cells. She burns natural gas, not heavy fuel oil — significantly lower particulate emissions. Practically: less engine vibration in lower-deck cabins.

What's NOT on World America

Things you might expect from her size that she doesn't have:

- **No Cirque du Soleil.** MSC's longstanding Cirque partnership ended before her delivery; she launched without it. The replacement is in-house production shows at the **World Theatre** and a comedy/karaoke lounge called **The Loft**.
- **No waterpark.** There's an Aqua Park (water-play features for kids and an outdoor pool deck) but nothing on the scale of Royal's Perfect Day at CocoCay or Carnival's Excel-class waterworks. The big aft attraction is the Venom Drop dry slide, not waterslides. Set the kids' expectations before boarding, not at the pool rail.
- **No traditional formal nights.** MSC has a "Gala Evening" once or twice per sailing (suit/cocktail-dress encouraged) but it's softer than the legacy "formal night" of Holland America or Cunard. Most guests dress smart-casual all week and put on something nicer on Gala Evening.

Cabin categories — the family calculus

Before you commit, check the cabin on the deck plan against the seven trouble spots in our **stateroom sanity check guide**: under the pool deck, over the theater, by the galley or the elevator bank, far forward, behind a lifeboat, or on a connecting door. Our cabin-by-cabin checker does not cover MSC ships yet, so the deck plan is the check. The cabin-organization article (**cruise-cabin-organization**) covers the small-space pragmatics once you've chosen.

For a family, the choices that matter most on World America:

- **Connecting cabins vs. one larger cabin.** MSC's family offerings include connecting staterooms and multi-berth cabins; which works depends on ages and how much door-between-you matters. Walk the deck plan before booking a specific cabin number.

-
- **Balcony on a December Caribbean week** earns its keep differently than in summer — sea-day sunrises and port-arrival views, with the caveat that December evenings on the balcony want a light layer.
 - **Mid-ship, mid-deck** cabins feel the least motion — worth weighting in December, when cold fronts can put chop in the Gulf and the Yucatán Channel (see **Section 7**).
 - **MSC Yacht Club** is MSC's ship-within-a-ship suite product — 159 suites on World America, private restaurant, private pool deck, private bar, butler service. Priced well above standard categories; family suites inside Yacht Club exist but sell early.

Pricing for this specific sailing lives with your booking — this pack deliberately doesn't quote cabin rates it can't verify.

Dining

World America has **20+ dining venues**. The dining map:

Included with your fare (no extra charge):

- **Four main dining rooms** on Decks 5 and 6: La Foglia, Esagono, Hexagon, Bubbles. Different room atmospheres, the same menu. MSC's MDRs run a slightly more formal European dining rhythm than the American lines — longer dinners, multiple courses, table service expected. With younger kids, ask for the earlier seating.
- **Il Mercato** (Deck 18) — the main buffet. Long hours; the upper-deck windows look down on the pool deck.
- **La Brasserie** (Deck 19) — 24/7 French-style casual. Crepes, fresh-baked bread, lighter food. This is where you go at 2 AM, and where the breakfast buffet is least crowded.
- **Luna Park Pizza & Burger** (Deck 6) — quick casual, included. The reliable kid-dinner fallback.
- **La Boca Grill** (Deck 18) — Argentinian/Latin American, included with fare.
- **Promenade Bites** (Deck 8) on the World Promenade — small plates and tapas, included.

Specialty dining (extra charge or part of a Specialty Dining Package):

- **Eataly** (Deck 8) — fresh pasta, wood-fired pizza, gelato. The first Eataly at sea. The reservation worth pre-booking on Day 1 if you only do one specialty meal — and the one specialty venue that genuinely works for kids.
- **Paxos** (Deck 8) — Greek seafood, open-air seating on the Promenade.
- **Butcher's Cut** — steakhouse.
- **Kaito Teppanyaki** and **Kaito Sushi Bar** — Japanese. Teppanyaki's flat-top theatrics are a family-dinner win if your kids will eat off a shared grill.
- **HOLA! Tacos & Cantina** — modern Mexican.
- **Jean-Philippe Chocolat & Café** — pastries and chocolate; partially included for some fare types, à la carte for others.
- **Masters of the Sea Pub** (Deck 7) — onboard microbrewery + pub food.

Drinks. MSC's drink package tiers (Easy / Easy+ / Premium Plus / Premium Extra) are different from NCL's or Royal's tiering, and kids' soda/mocktail packages price separately. **Whether anyone needs a package depends on what you actually drink** — the **drink-calculator** lets you put in your real consumption pattern. The companion article **Is the drink package worth it?** walks through the breakeven math with worked examples.

Connectivity

MSC's Wi-Fi packages are tier-based (Browse / Browse & Stream / Browse, Stream & Calls) and run separately from the drink-package promotions. Pricing is significantly cheaper pre-cruise than onboard. The **internet at sea guide** covers the cross-line baseline including how to avoid cellular roaming charges in port.

The family version of the right approach:

- One paid Wi-Fi plan on one parent's phone covers the "checking in with home" job
- Don't try to stream video at sea
- Use port-day cellular when possible (Roatán uses Honduras carriers, Mexican ports use Telcel/AT&T-Mexico, Ocean Cay has no terrestrial carriers at all)
- Kids' devices: download the week's entertainment BEFORE leaving home; ship Wi-Fi will not do it

-
- Keep one trusted person ashore informed via a daily one-line message; see **Section 6 — Emergency Contacts**
-

Section 2 — Day by Day

The day-by-day below uses this sailing's own MSC for Me itinerary (retrieved 2026-08-20). **Re-verify in the app as the date approaches** — times occasionally shift, especially around weather.

Weather lines quote typical early-December values — the Dec 5–12 window averaged over 2020–2024 from the Open-Meteo climate archive. Typical is not a forecast; the companion PWA shows the real forecast once each date is within ~16 days.

***This is not your plan.** What follows is one possible shape of the week, not a schedule to keep. Only a few things on it are actually fixed: the muster drill, sailaway, the ship's arrival and all-aboard times in each port, and anything you have already booked. Everything else is a suggestion you are free to ignore, reorder, or sleep through. A day spent entirely on your balcony is not a day wasted, and nothing here is a commitment you have made to anyone.*

Day 1 — Saturday, December 5 — PortMiami (embarkation)

Terminal: MSC Miami Cruise Terminal at PortMiami — the MSC-built terminal that opened in April 2025. ~492,678 square feet; MSC has marketed it as the world's largest cruise terminal. Different terminal from where Royal Caribbean and Carnival board at PortMiami; verify the MSC terminal address in the MSC for Me app before your taxi/Uber pickup.

Embark window: Typically 11:30 AM – 3:30 PM. Departure **5:00 PM** (MSC app itinerary); all-aboard runs about an hour before sailing. **Be at the terminal by 1:30 PM** to clear security and embarkation with margin — earlier with kids.

Typical December day: 78°F high / 65°F low, and December is Miami's dry season — only about 1 in 5 days sees measurable rain. Warm sun, genuinely cool evening.

Getting to PortMiami:

- **Miami International (MIA) → PortMiami:** Uber/Lyft \$30–45, 20–30 min. Taxi \$32 flat-rate.
- **Fort Lauderdale (FLL) → PortMiami:** Uber/Lyft \$60–90, 45–60 min.
- **If you're driving:** PortMiami garage parking ran \$35/day at Terminal AA (firsthand May 2026 — verify at booking); ~\$245 for the week. Offsite Miami long-term lots run \$7–14/day with shuttle service; with a family's luggage, weigh the shuttle hassle against the garage's walk-on convenience.

Pre-cruise hotel — strongly recommended. Same-day flights to an afternoon all-aboard are risky in any season. A Friday-night (Dec 4) stay in Miami Beach, Brickell, or Downtown gives you margin and a calmer Saturday morning with kids.

The realistic Day 1 timeline:

- **10:30 AM – 12:00 PM:** Arrive terminal, security, check-in. MSC's check-in is online via the MSC for Me app — complete it for the whole family before you arrive to skip a 20-minute queue.
- **12:30 PM:** Aboard. Cabins typically open by 1:30 PM; until then, lunch at the buffet (Il Mercato, Deck 18) or La Brasserie (Deck 19, calmer).
- **1:30 – 2:30 PM:** Cabins open. Meet your stateroom steward; drop carry-ons.
Register the kids at Doremiland Kids Clubs now — Day 1 registration lines are the shortest of the week.
- **~3:30 PM:** Mandatory muster drill — MSC's drill is partly app-based (watch the safety video in MSC for Me) plus an in-person check-in at your assigned station.
Every member of the family must complete both before sailing.
- **5:00 PM: Sailaway.** The World Promenade (Deck 8 aft, the seven-deck outdoor walkway around the Y-shaped stern) is the signature viewing location. Less crowded than the main pool deck; the wake unfolds directly below the rail.
- **6:00 – 8:00 PM:** Dinner — first night is the night to confirm your MDR table and seating time work for the kids' bedtimes.

What to pack in the carry-ons for Day 1: swimsuits (pools open before checked bags arrive), light layers (December Miami afternoons run ~78°F but the evening drops to the 60s and ship interior runs ~72°F), all medications, a change of clothes per person, passports (preferred for Caribbean itineraries — Roatán and Mexico are foreign ports), phone chargers, refillable water bottles, embarkation paperwork (printed or in MSC for Me), and whatever small entertainment keeps your kids happy in a check-in line. Checked bags may not arrive until 7–9 PM.

Money/card: Your MSC cruise cards are room key, ID, and onboard charge account in one. Kids' cards can be set to no-charge — decide at check-in. **Currency aboard: US Dollar.**

Day 2 — Sunday, December 6 — Cruising at sea

The settling-in day. The ship is heading southwest across the Gulf Stream and Yucatán Channel toward Roatán. Typical December sea-day weather on this leg: around 79/73 under the winter trades — breezy on deck, passing showers possible. (Sea-day values are estimated from adjacent-port normals.)

Morning: - The World Promenade (Deck 8 aft) for sunrise coffee. The wake view from the seven-deck Y-shaped aft is one of the ship's signature experiences. -

Breakfast at La Brasserie (Deck 19) — calmer than Il Mercato, French-style with fresh pastries and crepes. - **Doremiland morning session** for the kids while the grown-ups learn the ship.

Mid-morning to lunch — pick ONE:

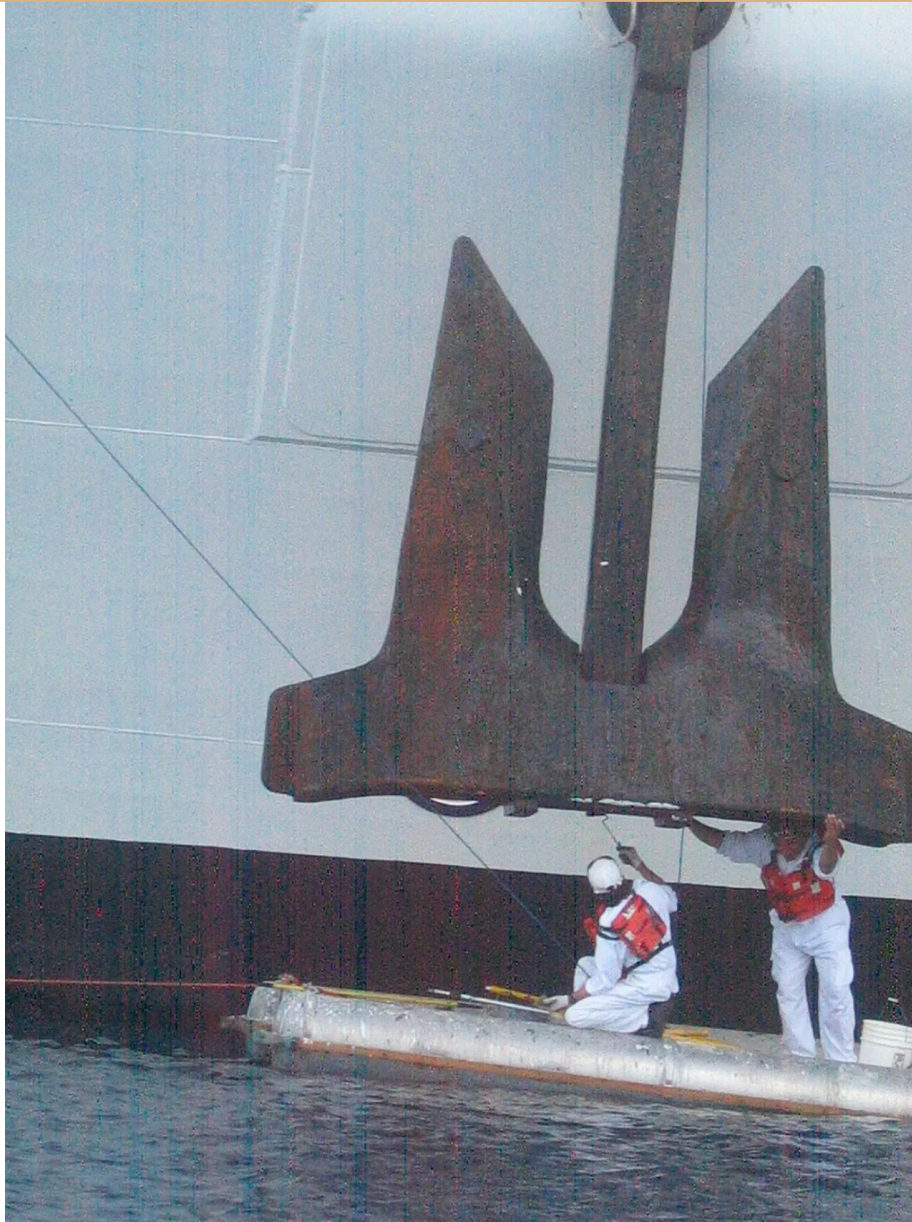
- **Climb the Venom Drop @ The Spiral.** The 11-deck dry slide is busiest mid-afternoon. The first hour after it opens (typically 10 AM) is the shortest line.
- **MSC Aurea Spa thermal-suite day pass** — sea-day mornings are when introductory rates appear. About 90 minutes is the right dose.
- **Eataly cooking demo** if scheduled — World America runs a pasta-making class on some sea days. Check the daily program.
- **The Galleria atrium** — three decks of LED ceiling, the day's best photo. Skip the rope line and just wander.

Afternoon: - Pool deck. December Caribbean sun is gentler than summer but still real — SPF 30 minimum on the kids, reapply. - **Trivia, port talks, live music** — MSC schedules a port-arrival briefing for Roatán. Worth attending; it's the port on this itinerary most worth planning around (weather and logistics both). - **Specialty dining reservations.** If you didn't book Eatly online pre-cruise, walk up to the host stand mid-afternoon. The 7:30 – 8:30 PM slots fill first — with kids, aim earlier anyway.

Evening — likely Gala Evening #1.

MSC typically schedules one of the week's two Gala Evenings for the first sea day of a 7-night sailing — verify in your daily program. Smart-casual is the standard; Gala invites something slightly nicer (jacket, cocktail dress) but not formal. The buffet stays open for families who'd rather skip it — or split: one parent takes the kids to Luna Park Pizza while the other dresses up, then swap next Gala.

Day 3 — Monday, December 7 — Roatán, Honduras



Roatán waterfront

Times (MSC app): 9:00 AM – 6:00 PM. World America docks at the **Port of Roatán at Coxen Hole** — the pier at the island’s working capital on the central-north coast, used by MSC, Royal Caribbean, NCL, and Virgin. (Roatán’s *other* cruise pier, **Mahogany Bay** — recently rebranded *Isla Tropical* — is Carnival Corporation’s exclusive facility; World America does **not** call there.)

The December honesty note, up front. Early December is the tail of Roatán’s rainy season: in the Dec 5–12 window, roughly **3 out of 4 days see measurable rain** (2020–2024 archive). Typical temps are a warm 81/77 — the rain is usually warm, often brief,

and the sun between showers is real. What it means practically: plan a flexible beach day, not a tight-schedule day; pack dry bags for phones and a packable rain shell; and hold excursion bookings loosely enough that a morning downpour doesn't sink the day. If the family gets a dry day, Roatán is the best snorkel stop of the week.

Roatán — reef, beaches, and the excursion-pricing catch. Roatán is the largest of Honduras's Bay Islands, sitting on the Mesoamerican Reef — the world's second-largest barrier reef. Clear water, friendly locals, snorkeling that converts non-snorkelers into snorkelers, and a pricing structure where ship-sponsored excursions cost noticeably more than independently arranged alternatives. The island is the cruiser-friendly face of Honduras.

Free / low-cost, at the Port of Roatán (Coxen Hole):

- The port's shopping-and-dining complex at the pier — shops, restaurants, tour desks, a duty-free area, and taxi/tour touts (haggle, and agree fares before you get in).
- Coxen Hole town is right at the pier — a real, workaday Honduran capital rather than a manicured pier village. Most cruisers head straight for a beach.

Paid (decide ahead):

- **West Bay Beach** — Roatán's signature beach. About 30–40 minutes by taxi from Coxen Hole (~\$6–10/person each way for a shared van; agree the fare first). White sand, calm water, restaurants, beach chairs ~\$10–15/day. The family day most cruisers come for.
- **Snorkel from West Bay Beach** — the reef is 30 yards offshore; bring your own masks and it's free. Best beach snorkeling on the itinerary for kids who can swim.
- **Roatán Institute for Marine Sciences (RIMS) dolphin programs** — at Anthony's Key Resort; \$90–180/person. Family-friendly and well-regulated.
- **Gumbalimba Park** — botanical garden + monkey/iguana encounter + zipline (\$40–80/person depending on bundle). The kid-pleaser if the beach day washes out early.

Pack for Roatán: swimsuits, reef-safe sunscreen (locally enforced — the reef is protected), dry bags, packable rain shells, water shoes, \$40–60 USD cash in small bills (US Dollar widely accepted; lempiras not necessary), sun hats.

Worth a look on the way in: the **Roatán port page**, its **photo gallery**, and the **Roatán logbook**. Build your day in the **Port Day Planner** before you go ashore.

Day 4 — Tuesday, December 8 — Costa Maya, Mexico



Costa Maya pier complex — purpose-built Mexican cruise port with the Yucatán coast beyond

Times (MSC app): 8:00 AM – 5:00 PM. Typical December day: 82/74, with better-than-even odds of a shower somewhere in the day and real sun between them.

Costa Maya — the purpose-built port, for better and worse. A Mexican government-built cruise port on the Yucatán’s Caribbean coast — purpose-designed for cruise ships. The pier complex is large, manicured, and contains shops, restaurants, a small zoo, swimming pools, and excursion meeting points. It’s the easiest of the Mexican ports — everything walkable from the ship — and the *least* “authentic Mexico” of the Yucatán cruise ports. That’s not a value judgment; it’s information. **For a family, this is the low-effort day of the week**, and after a Roatán beach day that’s a feature.

Easy-day option (no taxi needed):

- Stay in the Costa Maya port complex. **Tropicante** beach area is a 10-minute walk from the gangway — chairs \$10–15, drinks and food for purchase. The pool complex inside the port is free with your cruise card, shaded, and five minutes from re-boarding for the mid-day nap run.

Half-day option:

- **Mahahual village** (~10 min by shared shuttle, ~\$4/person each way) — a small fishing town turned cruiser stop. The *malecón* (waterfront walk) has restaurants, beach access, and shops less crowded than the port complex.

Full-day option:

- **Chacchoben Mayan ruins** (~45 min by tour bus). Independent operators outside the pier offer this for ~\$50/person; ship excursions run ~\$80–100. The one culture stop of the itinerary — smaller and less restored than Tulum but less crowded and closer. A real archaeological site; school-age kids who like temples will remember it.
- **Bacalar lagoon “Lake of Seven Colors”** — about 1.5 hours each way; full-day excursion only (\$120–180/person). Long bus legs — weigh against your kids’ bus tolerance.

Pack for Costa Maya: swimsuits, reef-safe sunscreen, light cover-ups, \$40–60 USD cash, small backpack. You can return to the ship for lunch easily.

Worth a look: the [Costa Maya port page](#), its [gallery](#), and the [Costa Maya logbook](#).

Day 5 — Wednesday, December 9 — Cozumel, Mexico



Cozumel waterfront

Times (MSC app): 9:00 AM – 7:00 PM. Verify the berth in the app — World America typically docks at one of three piers — **Punta Langosta** (downtown), **International Pier**, or **Puerta Maya**. Cozumel is the most heavily visited Caribbean port; expect several ships in port the same day.

Typical December day: 81/74 and breezy. One December-specific note: a **norther** (a cold front pushing down the Gulf) can stir the crossing and put chop on the island's west side — if one is passing, boat-snorkel tours may run bumpy or reschedule, and the calm-water beach parks become the better family call. The ship's daily program and the tour operators will know; ask morning-of.

Cozumel — the Western Caribbean's dive capital. The reef system off Cozumel — protected within Cozumel Reefs National Park since 1996 — delivers visibility consistently among the best in the Caribbean. If anyone in the family has ever wanted to try snorkeling, this is the day. Above water, Cozumel feels touristed in a familiar way — it's been a cruise stop for 50 years.

Easy-day option (no excursion needed):

- Stay near your pier. **Punta Langosta** puts you directly in downtown San Miguel — walk, find a real Mexican lunch (\$15–25/person at a non-tourist restaurant), shop at

Mercado Municipal (the local market, NOT the pier shops). International and Puerta Maya are 5–10 minutes from downtown by taxi (~\$10).

Half-day options:

- **Chankanaab Beach Adventure Park** (~\$50/person entry, ~15 min by taxi). Calm water, snorkel rentals, lounge and umbrella. **The best kid-snorkel setup on the itinerary** — protected water, gear on site, facilities at your back.
- **Paradise Beach** (~\$3 entry, free chairs with food/drink minimum, ~15 min by taxi). Lower-key with a real “Mexican beach club” feel.

Full-day options:

- **Palancar Reef snorkel tour** — *the iconic Cozumel experience*. Operators on the pier offer this for \$40–60/person (ship excursion: \$80–110). Two-hour tour, calm-day dependent in December. Confident swimmers only — Chankanaab is the better call for younger kids.
- **Tulum ruins** (ferry + bus; \$90–150 ship or ~\$80 independent). A long day with children; Chacchoben yesterday covers the Mayan itch with far less transit.

A note on shopping: Cozumel’s pier shops sell the same blanket, silver, and vanilla at every Caribbean port. The interesting shopping is at **Mercado Municipal** in San Miguel — vanilla, ceramics, leather, and food vendors at local-shopper prices.

For wheelchair users and limited mobility: Cozumel is genuinely accessible at the piers. Punta Langosta connects directly to a paved boardwalk into San Miguel. Beach clubs have beach wheelchairs available; ask in advance. Snorkel *boats* are typically NOT accessible — book a beach-snorkel instead.

Pack for Cozumel: swimsuits, reef-safe sunscreen, water shoes, sun hats, \$60–80 USD cash for entry fees and lunch, waterproof phone case.

Worth a look: the **Cozumel port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Cozumel logbook**.

Wednesday evening: the late departure means no rush back — all-aboard is likely ~6:30 PM; verify in the app.

Day 6 — Thursday, December 10 — Cruising at sea

The week's second sea day, running northeast toward the Bahamas. December note: this is the leg where a passing cold front shows up as wind and chop — typical values around 77/72, cooler than the outbound leg, and the deck wants a light layer after sunset. (Sea-day values estimated from adjacent-port normals; see **Section 7** if anyone's motion-prone.)

Morning ideas:

- **The Aurea Spa** if you didn't book it on Day 2 — thermal-suite day passes still appear in the morning slots.
- **Breakfast at La Brasserie** (Deck 19) — the second sea day is when the buffet rush has settled.
- **The Galleria atrium** at sunrise — the LED ceiling cycles a different scene by hour.
- **Kids club morning session** — and the parents' quiet hour it buys.

Mid-morning to early afternoon:

- **A laundry round.** Most MSC cabins have no washer/dryer; the self-service launderettes (verify location with your steward) are quietest on the second sea day. With a family's beach laundry, this is the day.
- **The pool deck** — with Ocean Cay tomorrow, today is the lounging day; tomorrow is full sun and less shade.
- **Specialty lunch.** Eataly's lunch service is quieter than dinner; walk-up availability is real midday.

Afternoon:

- **Port talk for Ocean Cay** — worth attending: it covers the beach map, what's included, and the arrival/departure window — which on this sailing determines the lighthouse-show question (see tomorrow).
- **Book any Ocean Cay cabana tonight** in the MSC for Me app if you want one — dockside prices run higher.

Evening — possible Gala Evening #2:

MSC schedules a second Gala Evening typically on the second sea day of a 7-night sailing. Tonight is also the calmest night for the specialty dinner you skipped earlier — Butcher's Cut, Paxos, and the Kaito venues have their shortest lines.

Day 7 — Friday, December 11 — Ocean Cay, Bahamas



The signature view — a “WE ♥ OCEAN CAY” boat-bench on white sand with the red-and-white striped Marine Reserve lighthouse on the spit behind it, beach umbrellas flanking either side

Times (MSC app): 8:00 AM – 8:00 PM — a late-departure call. The public listing used earlier showed 7:00 AM – 6:00 PM; the app’s window departs two hours later into the evening (and runs an hour longer overall), and that 8:00 PM departure is what makes the lighthouse evening show possible (below).

World America **docks alongside** Ocean Cay’s deep-water pier — no tender. Gangway to sand is about 5–10 minutes’ walk.



MSC Seaside (a sister-line ship in the same MSC berth) alongside Ocean Cay's deep-water pier — World America uses the same dock; no tender

Typical December day: 76/72 — Bahamian winter. Pleasant, breezy, only about 1 in 5 days sees rain. The water is cooler than summer but swimmable; kids will not care, grown-ups will notice. Limited natural shade matters less in December than July, but the sun is still real.

Ocean Cay — from aragonite mine to private island. MSC's private island — and only MSC's. Located in the Bimini chain of the Bahamas, ~65 miles east of Miami. Until 2015 the cay was an industrial aragonite-mining operation. MSC bought it, spent ~\$200 million and four years rebuilding it, and opened it in December 2019 as the Ocean Cay MSC Marine Reserve. **Your visit lands almost exactly on the island's seventh birthday.**

Ocean Cay is deliberately different from CocoCay, Half Moon Cay, and Castaway Cay. No waterpark, no helium balloon, no zip line, no overwater cabanas. What it has instead: an engineered swim lagoon, the lighthouse, the Marine Conservation Center, and seven named beaches with distinct personalities. First-timers expecting waterpark-and-fireworks will call it boring; veterans comparing private islands rate it highly for what it deliberately chooses not to be.

Free with your cruise fare:

- **All seven beaches** — South Beach, Lighthouse Bay, Bimini Beach, Pineapple Beach, Seakers Family Cove, Sunset Beach, Ocean House Beach. All sand, all included, all walkable from the pier or via free tram.
- **Loungers and umbrellas** at the main beach areas.
- **Tram service** — runs the spine of the cay, free, accommodates wheelchairs and strollers.
- **Buffet lunch** at the Marketplace Buffet near the pier (sit-down options at Boho House, Seakers, Smiling Fish — inclusion status varies by venue; verify in the app before counting on a complimentary sit-down).
- **The Beach Shack** at South Beach — chalkboard menu of cheeseburger, hot dog, fries, chicken nuggets, brownie. 11 AM to 4 PM.
- **Lighthouse climb** during posted hours.
- **Marine Conservation Center tours** — scheduled hours, free.

Paid add-ons: cabana rentals (pre-book in the app — typically cheaper than dockside), reserved beach beds, snorkel-gear rental, specialty restaurant covers, Spa Ocean Cay treatments.



The engineered swim lagoon viewed through the breakwater — calm, contained turquoise, with South Beach umbrellas visible at the far end

The beaches — the family read:

- **Seakers Family Cove** — protected family swim area with reef structure creating shallow zones. **Start here** — best for mixed swimming abilities, no parent-split required.
- **South Beach** — the center, the busiest, where the Beach Shack and the swim lagoon are.
- **Bimini Beach and Pineapple Beach** — twin west-side beaches, calmer water, often less crowded.
- **Lighthouse Bay** — east side, next to the tower. Quieter cove, photogenic.
- **Ocean House Beach** (far north) — longest walk, least crowded.
- **Sunset Beach** (south end) — quieter end of the cay.



Ocean Cay's red-and-white striped lighthouse seen across the cruise pier, with the thatched-roof Lighthouse Bar at its base and the swim-zone buoy line in the channel — the first thing you see from the gangway

The lighthouse evening show — now genuinely in play. The 15-minute lighting-and-music performance **runs only on overnight or late-departure calls** — and this sailing's MSC-app window is **8:00 AM – 8:00 PM, a late departure**. December sunset at Ocean Cay lands around 5:30 PM (approximate for the latitude and season), so there is real darkness before sail-away; whether the full show runs on your call is set by the ship's program, not this pack — check the daily program aboard. If it runs, **Lighthouse Bay** beach is the watching spot and the World Promenade the shipboard backup. If it doesn't, the lit tower at sail-away is still the week's best night photo.

The Marine Conservation Center. Real, not branding. The MSC Foundation operates it; coral nursery work, turtle-nesting protection on the cay's beaches. Free tours during scheduled hours; ~6-minute walk from the pier. Ocean Cay carries a Mission Blue Hope Spot designation — and it's the best 30 minutes of "the ocean is worth taking care of" your kids will get this week.

Pack for Ocean Cay:

- **MSC cruise cards** — required for entry and all purchases. **Cash is not needed on the cay.**
- **Reef-safe sunscreen** — December sun is gentler than summer, still reapply on the kids.
- **Waterproof phone case** for swim-lagoon photos.
- **Hats and sunglasses.**
- **Flip-flops AND water shoes** — the limestone shoreline gets rocky away from the swim cove.
- **A light layer for the sail-away** — December evening on deck is cool.

Pitfalls and things to know:

- **Beach Shack vs. sit-down venues.** Beach Shack is hot-dogs-and-nuggets. The buffet and labeled restaurants have real food.
- **Inclusion status not always clearly posted.** Verify in the app or ask a venue host.
- **Construction may be visible** on the cay's south spit.
- **No passport stamp.** Ocean Cay is a private island; you don't formally enter the Bahamas.

Worth a look: the **Ocean Cay port page** — extensive coverage of the cay's history, the beach personalities, the lighthouse show, the accessibility design, and logbook entries from prior visitors.

Day 8 — Saturday, December 12 — PortMiami (debarkation)

The realistic timeline:

- **6:00 – 8:00 AM:** Breakfast at the buffet (Il Mercato or La Brasserie). Eat now if your bags went out last night.

-
- **~7:00 AM:** Arrival and customs clearance. Self-disembarkation begins for families carrying their own bags.
 - **7:30 – 10:00 AM:** Walk-off in waves. **All passengers off by 10:00 AM** per MSC standard.

The bag situation. The night before, MSC asks you to place checked luggage outside your cabin door by ~11 PM with the color-coded debark tag. Bags go to the terminal overnight; you collect them in baggage claim before customs. With kids, seriously consider self-carry — one wave, no waiting, done.

Carry-on for debark morning: a change of clothes per person, all medications, passports, chargers, valuables, and anything you can't bear to lose if a bag is misrouted.

Getting from PortMiami to MIA: Uber/Lyft \$30–45, 20–30 minutes; Saturday-morning surge pricing is real, so pre-book if possible. For a domestic flight after 4 PM, leave PortMiami by 1:30 PM; MIA TSA runs 30–60 min during the Saturday cruise-return rush.

Killing hours before an evening flight: Bayfront Park / Bayside Marketplace (10-minute walk), Pérez Art Museum (\$20, air-conditioned, 15-minute walk), or Brickell by short Uber. PortMiami has no official luggage storage; some Bayside vendors hold bags for \$5–10/bag — confirm before counting on it.

And then you're home — thirteen days before Christmas, with the laundry done by the ship and the tree still up ahead of you.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

As early as possible — booking and big decisions

- **Confirm the booking details** with your travel agent or MSC directly: cabin category and numbers, final price, what's included (drinks package tier, Wi-Fi tier, gratuities prepaid or not, specialty dining package).

-
- **Buy travel insurance** if you want it. December 5 sails **after hurricane season ends (November 30)**, so named-storm risk is low — but trip-cancellation coverage for non-weather reasons (illness, family emergency, school schedules colliding) is worth considering for a family, where one person's flu can sink five fares. Specialist providers (Allianz, Travelex, Travel Guard) usually beat your home/auto insurer's add-on.
 - **Plan flights to Miami.** MIA is the obvious airport; FLL (~30 min north) is workable and sometimes cheaper. Arrive at minimum the day before sailing (Friday, December 4). Same-day flights are not advised — December brings fog and front-driven delays to the whole eastern seaboard.
 - **Choose the Friday-night hotel.** Brickell, Downtown Miami, or Miami Beach put you within easy reach of PortMiami on Saturday morning.

4 months before — soft logistics

- **MSC for Me accounts.** Set up online check-in for every member of the family; complete health questionnaires close to sailing (some MSC questions are time-limited).
- **Specialty dining reservations.** MSC opens specialty reservations ~3–4 months pre-cruise. **Eataly fills first.**
- **Excursion bookings.** Ship-sold excursions are bookable in MSC for Me; independent operators in Roatán and Cozumel typically have email-only booking 60–90 days out. For December, favor refundable/flexible bookings in Roatán (rainy-season odds — see **Day 3**).

2 months before — final commitments

- **Pre-pay gratuities** if you're going to (small discount vs. onboard rates) — and ask how MSC's service charge applies to the children on the booking; child rates differ and change, so get the current answer from MSC or your agent rather than a pack.
- **Drink package upgrades** — pre-cruise rates run 15–20% cheaper than onboard. Kids' soda packages price separately.
- **Confirm the pre-cruise hotel.**
- **Begin the packing list.** Reference **Section 4** below.

1 month before — final prep window

- **Photocopy passports** — keep copies in the cabin nightstand separate from the passports.
- **Print the emergency handoff card** and share it with one trusted person ashore.
- **Buy travel insurance** if you haven't.

14 days before — soft logistics

- **MSC online check-in closes** typically at 7 days pre-cruise — complete it earlier.
- **Print boarding documents** (or save offline in MSC for Me).
- **Begin physical packing** — and stage the Christmas prep you'll want done before you leave, because you land home on December 12 with thirteen days to go.

Day before — Miami arrival (Friday, December 4)

- **Fly into MIA or FLL.**
 - **Check into the Friday-night hotel.**
 - **Confirm porter/cab/Uber timing for Saturday morning.**
-

Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for early-December Caribbean)

This list is tuned for: **early-December Western Caribbean** — 76–82°F daytime highs falling to 65–77°F overnight depending on the stop (Miami and Ocean Cay are the cool ends; Roatán barely drops), a real chance of rain in Roatán and the Mexican ports, and cool, breezy December evenings on deck. **Four port days, two sea days, one private-island beach day** (Ocean Cay). **MSC's smart-casual evening dress culture** (no strict formal nights; one or two Gala Evenings invite a slightly dressier outfit, jacket not required).

The one-sentence difference from a summer Caribbean list: **add a real light layer per person and rain protection, subtract nothing.**

Documents and money

- **Passports** (strongly preferred for Caribbean itineraries — Roatán and Mexico are foreign ports)
- Photocopies of passports (separate location from the passports themselves)
- Travel insurance policy and emergency phone number (printed)
- Credit card + debit card (separate locations, in case one is lost)
- **\$200–300 USD cash** in small bills (\$1s, \$5s, \$10s) for tips, taxis, and small purchases ashore — broken across wallet, day-pack, and cabin safe
- MSC cruise documents (printed boarding passes + saved offline in MSC for Me)
- Kids' documents in the same folder as yours — one folder, one place

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications in original prescription bottles
- Phones + chargers + a power bank
- Refillable water bottles
- Light layers (December Miami evenings drop to the 60s; ship interior runs ~72°F)
- Swimsuits (pools open before checked bags arrive)
- A change of clothes per person
- Sunglasses, sun hats, reef-safe sunscreen
- Whatever keeps your kids happy in a line

Daytime — port and ship

- **4–5 swimsuits per swimmer** (in the water most days; rotation beats dampness)
- **2 swim cover-ups each**
- **3–4 quick-dry t-shirts or tank tops**
- **2 pairs lightweight shorts**

-
- **1–2 pairs lightweight pants** (Chacchoben ruins; mosquito-protective for inland excursions)
 - **1 lightweight long-sleeve shirt each** (sun at Ocean Cay; evening deck)
 - **1 light cardigan/fleece or wrap each** — this is the December line-item: evening deck, sail-away, and the ship's AC all want it

Rain gear — the December addition

- **Packable rain shell per person** (Roatán's rainy-season odds are real — see **Day 3**)
- **Dry bags** for phones and cameras on port days
- A folding travel umbrella if you're an umbrella family (shells beat umbrellas on a breezy tender pier)

Evening — ship dining

- **4–5 smart-casual outfits** — sundresses, lightweight pants + nicer top, dress slacks + button-down. MSC's evening dress code is European-casual: nicer than American casual, less formal than American legacy lines.
- **1 Gala Evening outfit** (cocktail dress, dressy jumpsuit, dress slacks + jacket, dressy separates) — wearable twice across the week's two Gala Evenings
- **Comfortable dress shoes** (low heels; long carpeted corridors and gentle motion)
- Kids: one “nicer” outfit covers both Galas; nobody is checking

Footwear

- **Comfortable walking shoes** (sneakers or sandals)
- **Water shoes** (Cozumel snorkeling, rocky shorelines, Ocean Cay limestone) — strongly recommended, kids especially
- **Flip-flops** (pool deck and cabin)
- **Dress shoes** — one pair per person only

Toiletries

- All prescription medications (original bottles, in carry-on)
- Over-the-counter standbys: Tylenol, Advil, Imodium, Benadryl, children's doses of each, Dramamine or Bonine (see **Section 7**)
- Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30+ minimum; **reef-safe is enforced in Roatán and Cozumel**)
- After-sun aloe gel
- Insect repellent (DEET 25%+ or picaridin) for inland excursions
- Toothbrushes, toothpaste, deodorant, basic toiletries
- Hair care for humidity
- Lip balm with SPF

Accessories and essentials

- Polarized sunglasses
- Sun hats with brims
- Small daypack for port days (one per adult)
- Waterproof phone cases (snorkeling + Ocean Cay swim lagoon)
- Beach towels? — MSC provides pool/beach towels at the pool deck and at Ocean Cay; don't pack them
- Power adapter — World America has US and EU outlets; a USB-multiplier strip handles the family's device pile
- E-readers or books for sea days; downloaded content on kids' devices — **download before leaving home**

Skip — what NOT to bring

- **Iron or steamer** — prohibited in cabins; ships provide ironing facilities
- **Candles** — prohibited (fire hazard)
- **Multipack hangers** — cabins have adequate hangers
- **Heavy jewelry** — the cabin safe handles essentials; leave high-value pieces home

-
- **Cash-heavy wallet** — Ocean Cay is cashless; ship is cashless; Mexican ports take USD; only Roatán benefits from small-bill USD
 - **Multiple formal outfits** — MSC's "Gala" is two evenings max and not strict formal
 - **Beach umbrella or pop-up shade** — Ocean Cay rents umbrellas; the ship pool deck has shade
-
-

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The numbers below are calibrated for this itinerary. For a budget tuned to your cabin choice, drinking habits, excursion appetite, and tipping pattern, the **cruise-budget-calculator** builds a personalized total — usually within 5% of what you'll actually spend if you input honestly. **For a family, multiply the per-person lines soberly** — four fares' worth of "little" add-ons is how a budget dies.

What's included in your fare

- Your cabins
- All meals in the MDRs, buffet (Il Mercato, La Brasserie), Luna Park Pizza & Burger, La Boca Grill, Promenade Bites
- Soft drinks, juice, coffee, tea at most venues (specifics depend on your fare type — Bella, Fantastica, or Aurea)
- Onboard entertainment in the World Theatre, The Loft, Luna Park Arena
- Kids clubs (Doremiland) — included, registration required
- Pools, fitness center, the Venom Drop dry slide
- No tendering on this itinerary — World America docks alongside at all ports
- Cabin steward and dining-room service

What's NOT included

The realistic add-on costs, per person unless noted:

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Drinks package (if not in fare)	\$400–700 adult — Easy: ~\$50/day · Premium Plus: ~\$80/day; kids' soda packages price separately
Wi-Fi package	\$80–180 — varies by tier; one plan can cover the family's check-in-with-home job
Service charge / gratuities	~\$119 adult — \$17/day standard (\$23/day Yacht Club), rate effective May 11, 2026; child rates differ — verify the current schedule with MSC or your agent
Specialty dining	\$0–250 — Eataly ~\$45 · Butcher's Cut ~\$55 · Paxos ~\$40 (per meal)
Shore excursions — Roatán	\$0–150 — taxi to West Bay ~\$15; snorkel tour ~\$40 indep / ~\$100 ship
Shore excursions — Costa Maya	\$0–100 — port complex free; Chacchoben ~\$50 indep / ~\$80 ship
Shore excursions — Cozumel	\$0–110 — Chankanaab ~\$50; ship Palancar ~\$95
Ocean Cay add-ons	\$0–250 — cabanas \$150–300 (one covers the family); snorkel rental ~\$25
Spa treatments	\$0–500 — massages \$130–200 · thermal-suite day pass \$40
Photos	\$0–250 — Photo Package ~\$200 (worth it on Gala Evening with everyone dressed)

A realistic mid-range family shape (per adult, on top of cruise fare)

Item	Cost
Gratuities (\$17/day × 7)	\$119
Wi-Fi (one Browse package, shared job)	\$90
Specialty dining (Eataly once, family)	\$45

Item	Cost
Roatán: taxis + chairs + lunch	\$50
Costa Maya: pools free + lunch	\$30
Cozumel: Chankanaab + lunch	\$75
Ocean Cay: included day + extras	\$30
Airport transfers MIA ↔ port	\$80
Pre-cruise hotel (Friday night, split across the party)	\$90
Tips above and beyond	\$30
Total above fare, per adult	~\$640

Frugal version (no specialty dining, no packages, port-complex days): **~\$350/adult above fare**. The child multiplier is real but smaller — no drinks package, reduced service charge, shared excursion economics. Run your own honest numbers in the **calculator**.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section. Fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore.

The family handoff card

Copy this, fill in your specifics, and share:

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISERS:

CABIN(S):

SHIP: MSC World America

LINE: MSC Cruises

SAILING: December 5 – 12, 2026

FROM: MSC Miami Cruise Terminal, PortMiami,
Miami, FL, USAITINERARY: Miami → Roatán (Honduras) →
Costa Maya (Mexico) → Cozumel (Mexico)
→ Ocean Cay (Bahamas) → Miami

TRAVEL AGENT:

EMERGENCY (24/7) – US State Dept, Overseas
Citizens Services (can locate the ship and
reach MSC through official channels, no cost):
+1 (888) 407-4747 (US/Canada)
+1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)

MSC GUEST RELATIONS (to reach a guest aboard –
business hours ET; have ship name, sail date,
guest name & booking #):
+1 (877) 665-4655

SHIP-TO-SHORE: In emergency, MSC relays to ship

NEAREST EMBASSY/CONSULATE BY PORT:

Miami, FL – US domestic; call 911
Roatán, HN – US Consulate Tegucigalpa:
+504 2236-9320
(after-hours emergency)
Costa Maya, MX – US Consulate Mérida:
+1 (844) 528-6611 (US) / 999 689-0660
Cozumel, MX – US Consulate Mérida (as above);
also Cancún Consular Agency:
+1 (844) 528-6611 (US)
Ocean Cay, BS – MSC private island; ship's
medical & security on-island

FAMILY MEDICAL:

Allergies:

Medications:

Conditions:

Insurance: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:

Track at: </tools/ship-tracker.html>
or marinetraffic.com (search "MSC World America")

What an at-home contact actually does

If they don't hear from you for 36+ hours and they're worried:

1. **Don't panic.** Cruise Wi-Fi is unreliable and silence usually means signal, not emergency.
2. **For a true emergency, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** (above) — it runs 24/7 and can locate the ship and reach MSC through official channels at no cost. To pass a non-urgent message aboard, **MSC Guest Relations** (877-665-4655, business hours ET) can relay to the ship.
3. **Reach your travel agent** if there's a booking question or if MSC's line isn't getting through.
4. **If MSC confirms an incident:** US Consulate Tegucigalpa for Honduras; US Consulate Mérida for Mexican ports; for Bahamas the ship's resources cover Ocean Cay.
5. **Track the ship's position** using the link above for context.

What you should pack for emergencies

- Printed list of the family's medications, allergies, and emergency contacts (in the cabin nightstand)
- Photocopies of passports (separate from the passports)
- Travel insurance policy number (printed)
- The handoff card above, in your phone's notes app and shared with one trusted person

Section 7 — Seasickness

Here December differs from the calm late-spring weeks, and it's worth saying plainly: **early-December Western Caribbean is generally comfortable, but cold fronts (“northers”) cross the Gulf of Mexico and the Yucatán Channel in winter and can bring a day of real wind and chop.** The exposure points are the Day-2 southwest transit, the Day-6 northbound run, and — for tour boats rather than the ship — Cozumel's west side on a front day. A 216,000-ton ship shrugs off most of it; a motion-sensitive stomach notices anyway.

If anyone in the family is prone to motion sickness:

- **Bonine (meclizine)** — once-daily, less drowsy than Dramamine. Check children's dosing with your pediatrician BEFORE the trip, not from the ship's shop label.
- **Sea-bands (acupressure wristbands)** — placebo or not, many find them effective, and they're the zero-side-effect option for kids.
- **Ginger** (capsules, tea, candies) — mild but real anti-nausea effect.
- **Scopolamine patches** (prescription, behind-the-ear) — strongest option for adults, prescribed pre-cruise; 3-day duration.
- **Cabin choice: mid-ship and mid-deck** feels the least motion. Decks 8–12 mid-ship are the calm zone.

If someone gets sick onboard: the ship's medical center stocks IV anti-nausea medication. Bring travel insurance — onboard medical bills are real and not covered by US health insurance.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

Cell service and roaming

- **At sea** — ship Wi-Fi only; airplane mode ON, and check the kids' devices too — a phone quietly roaming on the ship's cell tower at \$5–10/minute is a classic final-bill surprise.
- **Roatán** — Honduran carriers Tigo, Claro. US carriers roam at international rates; check your plan.
- **Costa Maya / Cozumel** — Mexican carriers Telcel, AT&T Mexico. US T-Mobile customers get included Mexico roaming; Verizon and AT&T-US day passes run ~\$10/day.
- **Ocean Cay** — no terrestrial cellular. Ship Wi-Fi only if you bought the package; otherwise the family is offline for the day. This is fine. It might be the best day.

Currency

- **Aboard:** US Dollar.
- **Roatán:** US Dollar widely accepted; lempiras not necessary. Small bills (\$1, \$5, \$10) are best.
- **Costa Maya / Cozumel:** US Dollar widely accepted at tourist-facing businesses; pesos get better prices off the tourist track. Credit cards at sit-down restaurants. Pier ATMs charge ~\$3/withdrawal.
- **Ocean Cay:** MSC cruise card only; no cash needed.

Tipping ashore

- **Roatán:** 10–15% on restaurant bills, \$1–2/person on guided tours.
- **Costa Maya / Cozumel:** 10–15% on restaurant bills, 10–20 pesos for taxi drivers, \$5–10/person for half-day tours.
- **Ocean Cay:** gratuities are bundled into your fare; \$1–2 to a bartender who took good care of you is appreciated, not expected.

Onboard tipping (gratuities)

MSC's daily Hotel Service Charge ran **\$17/person/day** for standard cabins and **\$23/person/day** for Yacht Club as of the May 11, 2026 rate change, charged to your onboard account; **children's rates differ by age band — get the current schedule from MSC or your agent for your booking.** For the all-in tipping picture across auto-grats plus typical cash tips, the **cruise-tipping-calculator** gives a calibrated read; **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the longer read.

Section 9 — The Family Cruise Rhythm

Nobody sets your rhythm on a family sailing — that's the point, and the trap. The pattern that works:

- **Day 1: register, then relax.** Kids-club registration (Doremiland) on boarding day, cabin cards configured (charging on or off per kid), muster done as a family, then sailaway from the World Promenade. The whole week gets easier when Day 1's admin is done by dinner.
- **Pick one fixed meeting point.** The World Galleria is the natural one — central, unmistakable, three decks of LED ceiling nobody can miss. "If we're separated, Galleria, deck 6, on the hour."
- **Anchor the day on dinner.** Same MDR table, same time, every night — the one fixed point that makes the rest of the day free-form. Earlier seating with younger kids; the buffet as the pressure-valve on port days that run long.
- **Split-shift the Galas.** If dressing everyone up twice sounds like work, split it: one parent takes the kids casual, the other enjoys Gala #1; swap for Gala #2. Or dress everyone once and take the photo — the Photo Package earns its keep on Gala night.
- **One "everyone chooses" rule.** Each family member picks one thing for the week — a port activity, a specialty dinner, a show — and everyone shows up for everyone's pick. The Venom Drop will be somebody's.

-
- **Port days: one plan, one backup.** December's rain odds (Roatán especially) reward a loose plan with a named fallback over a tight itinerary.
 - **Last night (Friday, post-Ocean Cay):** bags out by ~11 PM if using MSC's overnight bag service — or skip it and self-carry. Do the debark-morning brief at dinner: who carries what, where you meet if separated at the terminal.
-

Section 10 — Family Considerations on MSC

Family cruising on MSC is good, but **different** from Royal Caribbean, Carnival, or NCL. The differences worth knowing:

- **The family footprint is the Family Aventura district — The Harbour** (the outdoor family zone: water park, Cliffhanger swing ride, themed playground, ropes course, free grab-and-go), **Doremiland** (the kids clubs, built with LEGO and Chicco partnerships, age-banded rooms — included with your fare, registration required, do it Day 1), and the **Sportsplex**. Kids-club hours vary by day — port days run longer morning sessions; check the daily program. **Luna Park Arena** hosts the family-scale entertainment.
- **European cruise culture.** MSC is an Italian-headquartered line with a European passenger demographic that often outnumbers the American share even on Caribbean sailings. Your kids will hear Italian, French, Spanish, and German in the corridors — treat it as a feature. Most crew are multilingual; signage is English-first.
- **A different evening rhythm.** MDR dinners run longer and more course-paced than American lines. With younger kids: earlier seating, and Luna Park Pizza & Burger as the honest fallback on the nights the MDR pace won't survive bedtime.
- **December kid-density.** December 5–12 sits after Thanksgiving and before school holiday breaks — expect fewer children aboard than summer or the Christmas/New Year's sailings that bracket it. The kids clubs are calmer; the pool deck is not a school-holiday scrum. (Expectation from the calendar, not a measured count.)

-
- **Holiday season aboard.** Early-December sailings fall inside the ship's holiday season — expect seasonal décor and programming in some form, and verify the specifics in the daily program rather than promising the kids anything particular.
 - **For first-time MSC families coming from another line:** the MSC for Me app is the operational hub — daily program, dining reservations, kids-club hours, ship map. **Download and log in for the whole family before sailing.** Gratuities are called “Service Charge.” Drink-package tier names don't map to your previous line's.
-

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is anyone's first cruise, a few foundational notes (the **first-cruise guide** is the deeper read; the **Cruising Duck tradition** is the one piece of cruise culture worth knowing in advance — and a family with kids will find the ducks without help; the **cruise-tech and photography guide** helps you pack the right cables, mounts, and waterproof cases for World America's signature views):

- **The cabin is small.** Even Balcony cabins are smaller than a budget hotel room. You're not living in the cabin; you're sleeping in it. The ship is your living room.
- **You can't get lost.** Every elevator lobby has a deck map. Every crew member can direct you. The Galleria (Decks 6–8 mid-ship) is the orienting landmark — and your family meeting point.
- **You don't need to book everything ahead.** Most days unfold with significant unplanned time. That's by design.
- **Tipping is built in.** Beyond the auto-gratuity, you don't need to tip every interaction. A few dollars to a great steward at week's end is appreciated, not expected.
- **Don't try to do everything.** A week is enough time to do what matters. Trying to do every show, every venue, every excursion will burn the family out by Day 4 — and the kids will remember the unstructured pool afternoon over the third scheduled activity anyway.

The thing nobody tells first-timers: the best moments of a cruise are usually unplanned. The conversation at the rail on Day 3. The kids discovering the Venom Drop line moves fastest at 10 AM. The 30 minutes you spent watching the wake unfold from the World Promenade while everyone else was still at breakfast.

Leave room for that.

Closing

This pack is the calm read on one specific week — yours, together.

Soli Deo Gloria. All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent — no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped your family, that's the whole point.

Safe sailing.

Sources | Ship: **MSC World America**. Ports: **Miami, Roatán, Costa Maya, Cozumel, Ocean Cay**. Articles: **MSC Seaside service review, Royal Caribbean vs MSC**. Tools: **drink-calculator, port-day-planner, port-tracker, ship-tracker**. Reference: **first-cruise, internet-at-sea, packing-lists, cabin-organization article**. Sailing schedule: iCruise + cruise-timetable listings for the Dec 5, 2026 departure (verified 2026-08-20); ship/port facts inherited from the v0.1.8 pack's verified sidecar; December weather normals computed from the Open-Meteo ERA5 archive (Dec 5–12 window, 2020–2024) on 2026-08-20. |